

who will be relieved to discover that Natasha is a minor character, and that I would not be burdened with this, well, far-from-comely image as I made my way through the rest of the novel? Some of all this is actually very funny, as when the Shiv Sena, very thinly disguised by Shanghvi as the Hindu People's Party, proposes a ban on masturbation punishable by prison or a Rs 5,000 fine—and he pads the books out with plenty of good and bad sex, most memorably between a male politician and a female buffalo. *Lost Flamingoes*, it must be said, is not a book for prudes.

Shanghvi is an articulate, buccaneering, confident writer with a love for alliterative adjectives and sentimental flights of fancy. His extended descriptions of photography and pottery use the anthropomorphic adjectival devices of the art critic. Karan's photos, for instance, are "thuggish, mesmeric, galvanic". And then there are the flamingoes of the title, who never actually seem to be very lost, unlike the frail humans for whom they seem to serve as a metaphor. "Staring skywards, at the thundering shadow that was approaching, Karan felt it could herald the apocalypse. Flamingoes, thousands of them, were flying by in a giant skein: the birds had tight, spindled legs and large, serrated wings and their graceful necks were so firmly held that they looked like freshly serviced and strings on a sitar."

The most important character in the novel is not a human, or an animal, but the city in which most of the story takes place. Karan—a new migrant to the city—watches the flamingoes and thinks, "So this is Bombay, monster muse, part witch, part clown, always absurd, often charming—my rogue ballad; this is Bombay, *meri jaan*." Chor Bazaar, the Ban Ganga tank, Worli Sea Face and the Kanheri caves are among the key locations of *Lost Flamingoes*, which is careful to avoid slumdog territory. And the novel ends, rather too neatly, in Bandra, with one of Bombay's many recent moments of despair, the great floods of 2005.

As you will have guessed by now (or if you read his previous novel, *The Last Song of Dusk*), Shanghvi has a way with words, and he knows it. There are probably too many of them in this book, and a brave editor might have advised a little thinning-out. However, one can't help but admire Shanghvi for his ambition and brio, and his tale is both entertaining and thought-provoking. But he is too keen to be both amusing and profound at the same time—and the novel slips frequently into that ugly gap between hilarity and despair. He might have learnt something from one of his own characters, Samar, about whom Karan, the photographer, says, "He's always being funny and clever; he's trying too hard." ■

TOP 10

A monthly list of national bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG

FICTION

1. The White Tiger
Aravind Adiga, HarperCollins
2. The 3 Mistakes of My Life
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa
3. Slumdog Millionaire
Vikas Swarup, Black Swan
4. The Associate
John Grisham, Arrow
5. Sea of Poppies
Amitav Ghosh, Penguin/Viking

NON-FICTION

1. Stay Hungry Stay Foolish
Rashmi Bansal, CIE-IIM
2. Imagining India: Ideas for the New Century
Nandan Nilekani, Penguin
3. The Secret
Rhonda Byrne, Atria
4. Outliers: The Story of Success
Malcolm Gladwell, Allen Lane
5. The Audacity of Hope: Thoughts on Reclaiming the American Dream
Barack Obama, Three Rivers Press/Canongate

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

FICTION

6. Unaccustomed Earth
Jhumpa Lahiri, Random House India
7. Six Suspects
Vikas Swarup, Doubleday
8. The Rozabal Line
Ashwin Sanghi, Westland

NON-FICTION

9. The 24x7 Marriage: Smart Strategies for Good Beginnings
Vijay Nagaswami, Westland
10. Curfewed Night
Basharat Peer, Random House
15. We are Like That Only: Understanding the Logic of Consumer India
Rama Bijapurkar, Penguin

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Teksons, Land Mark, Crossword; Mumbai: Oxford, Shah Book Stall, Modern Book Shop; Bangalore: Gangarams, Land Mark; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Land Mark

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